

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 41

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A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of John Randall "Randy" Rayburn.

WHEREAS, we were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of John Randall "Randy" Rayburn; and

WHEREAS, Randy Rayburn was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, the son of Charles Guy and Kathleen Butler Rayburn, Randy Rayburn was born on January 24, 1950, in Memphis and grew up in nearby Milan; and

WHEREAS, after finishing his degree at the University of Tennessee, Knoxville, he discovered the expansive and inviting social scene of Nashville, where he quickly became a central figure in both political and culinary matters; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rayburn acted as a nexus for the various social circles and spheres that inhabited Nashville in the 1970s and 1980s, and his parties atop Squirrel Hill, populated by members of his "New Trashvillians" guest list, became legendary for their scope and hospitality; and

WHEREAS, a lifelong Democrat and active political entity, Mr. Rayburn became known both for his skills as an information broker in the restaurant scene and for his sealed lips concerning the more sensitive matters of his clientele; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rayburn worked for more than ten restaurants in Nashville before deciding he would utilize his experience, talent, and insight to create his own restaurant, Sunset Grill, in 1990; and

WHEREAS, Sunset Grill instantiated Mr. Rayburn's well-known and beloved presence; it became a landmark of the city where high quality conversation, characters, and cuisine could always be delighted in, and some 800 people a day were served; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rayburn's farseeing vision for Sunset Grill can be seen in its pivot to California-inspired cuisine and American eclecticism over rarified fine dining and in such innovations as wine-by-the-glass and outdoor patio dining, which are now staples of the Nashville dining scene; and

WHEREAS, he successfully managed Sunset Grill while opening and maintaining two other renowned restaurants in the city, Cabana and Midtown Cafe, but seeing the changing desires of the market, Mr. Rayburn decided to close Sunset Grill's doors in 2014; and

WHEREAS, while COVID-19 put a heavy strain on restaurants and marked the end of Cabana, Mr. Rayburn seized an opportunity to help jumpstart the Elliston Place Soda Shop by enlisting his coworker of thirty-seven years, former general manager of Sunset Grill, and business partner in Cabana, Craig Clift, to run the new venture, and both Midtown Cafe and Elliston Place Soda Shop continue to thrive after the pandemic; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Rayburn maintained a loving friendship to the famous *Tennessean* publisher John Seigenthaler, who frequented Sunset Grill and Midtown Cafe, and Mr. Rayburn kept a portrait of his friend hanging in Midtown Cafe to honor him; and

WHEREAS, outside of his career as a restaurateur, Mr. Rayburn was renowned for his generosity to those in need, his impressive consumption of the written word, and his profound capacity for kindness; and

WHEREAS, he was also deeply devoted to his family, and he had an obvious and admirable devotion to his two sons, Duke and Dean, often expressing his wish that he had become a father sooner; and

WHEREAS, Randy Rayburn will be sadly mourned yet fondly remembered by his sons; their mother, Sonata Stanton Helbig; cousins, Jimmy Lee Trobaugh and Charlotte Brownlee; and other family members; and

WHEREAS, Randy Rayburn leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional gentleman and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of John Randall "Randy" Rayburn, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Rayburn.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.